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The slaughtered camel

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Section Title(S)

7. THE POLITICS OF INTERPRETATION: METAPHORS OF HIERARCHY RECONSIDERED • A SUMMARY OF THE NOBLE VERSION

Parkin has suggested that “culture is people interpreting” (1982:xlvi), and in this chapter I focus on the positional character of interpretation (and therefore culture). In North Eastern and Eastern Africa there are many examples of what are variously called “remnant peoples”, “outcasts” and “lowcasts”. Such terms are often chosen to depict groups who display significant cultural, dietary or organizational contrasts to the larger ethnic groups among whom they live.¹ The question here is how one such group, the boon among the Hubeer, interpret the symbols their superiors use to degrade them with.

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A SUMMARY OF THE NOBLE VERSION

I will here only briefly repeat the noble version of commoners' degradation. In some respects the commoners stand out as an inverted mirror image of values cherished by nobles. The commoners are “enemies within” that constitute a negative example for the nobles. The commoners are often talked about in contemptuous ways. Nearly all of the terms used for them are also pejoratives. Other terms, which are not necessarily derogatory, acquire a negative ring when used for talking about the commoners. Still, many of these terms, as well as their exegesis, are considered highly amusing by the nobles. The pejoratives have a marked focus on bodily and mental traits thought to make out clearly discernable differences between nobles and commoners.

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It is said that the commoners have "hard hair" in relation to the "soft hair" of the nobles. Various terms for hard or thick hair are used as synonyms for commoners: jareer, timo adag etc. Frequent are also jokes about the large amount of razors a commoner needs for shaving the hair on his head. Soft hair, by  161 contrast, is a sign of beauty allegedly possessed only by real Somalis and not "the Africans" (Afrikaanka), a category to which the commoners are sometimes said to belong. This belief is so widespread that a gesture is usually sufficient to make someone else understand what is being talked about. Thus, to slightly twist the hair at one's temple between thumb and forefinger is synonymous to saying the word jareer.

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. Some well-documented such cases include the Watta (Cerulli 1922) and the Torrobo (Galaty 1977; 1979; 1986) and are also to be found among the Dizi (Haberland 1984), the Dime (Todd 1977, 1978), the Gurage (Schack 1964), Macha Oromo (Hultin 1987; H.S. Lewi 1970) and the Konso (Hallpike 1968). Though I am not suggesting that the perspective applied in this chapter is valid in all these cases, at least problems of a similar character can be found among them.

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